leadership, leave aside the chief himself'.[33] That first cybershakha on 25 September 1999 was aimed at NRIs.[34]

By 2003, the RSS had started organising software shakhas or 'IT Milans', which were first reported from Pune (Maharashtra), Bengaluru (Karnataka), Hyderabad (Andhra Pradesh), Chennai (Tamil Nadu) and Noida (UP). They included everything from 'Powerpoint presentations on the RSS's community work to Yoga' and 'video conferences'. BJP leader Ram Madhav, then still with the RSS, said that 'the first software shakha was held in 2003-04. It's a new experiment to connect with emerging sections of professionals.'[35] Initiatives like these were later localised and scaled up in local languages in states like Karnataka.

The Sangh also aggressively uses publications in local languages, neatly differentiated and targeted. In Karnataka, for example, it publishes two Kannada magazines. According to Holla, '*Vikrama*[36] [for mass connect] has a weekly circulation of about 20,000 in Kannada, and *Aseema*[37] is for intellectuals, with a monthly circulation of 5,000 plus.'[38]

Importantly, the BJP being in power in Karnataka was of great help to the RSS. As Vadhiraj said, 'BJP has increased in Karnataka because of RSS, but RSS has also increased because of BJP.'[39] He pointed to the controversy over Tipu Sultan, the eighteenth-century Muslim ruler of Mysore who died fighting the British in 1799, but whose legacy is bitterly divided between those who revere him as a freedom fighter and Hindu nationalists who see him as an oppressor of Hindus. Since the early 2000s, controversies around the legacy of Tipu have regularly erupted into political slugfests between the Congress and the BJP. When the Congress-led Siddaramaiah government decided to celebrate Tipu Jayanti from 10 November 2015 onwards as an annual event to commemorate India's 'first freedom fighter', the BJP protested vociferously. The Yediyurappa-led BJP government, which won power in Karnataka in 2019, scrapped these plans within three days of taking office, a move that Siddaramaiah characterised as being 'against minorities'.[40] In Vadhiraj's view, this controversy played a role in the growth of the RSS. 'Even Siddaramaiah helped us by introducing Tipu Jayanti,' he